

## □ Reflection 1 □

### What Dharma Is Not : ధర్మము అంటే ఏమి కాదు

On the recovery of a Sanskrit word that has lost its meaning in translation

**A note to the reader.** This reflection is a linguistic and historical inquiry, not a polemic. It is not directed at any contemporary conflict, group, or tradition. Its only aim is to recover the original meaning of one Sanskrit word — *dharma* — by examining what it actually meant in the time and place where the *Bhagavad Gītā* was composed. Where the recovery has implications for the present, the reader is left to draw them.

#### The word that does not translate

*The Bhagavad Gītā* uses the word *dharma* over thirty times. Not once does it mean "religion" in the modern sense of a system of beliefs that one belongs to in distinction from other systems.

This is not a controversial claim among Sanskrit scholars; it is a settled point of philology. But it is almost entirely unknown to most readers of the *Gītā* in English, because the word "religion" appears so frequently in English translations of the text — usually as the rendering of *dharma* — that the equivalence has come to seem self-evident. It is not.

The English word *religion* carries, today, a very specific set of associations: that the world's peoples are divided into communities defined by competing belief systems; that each such community has its own scriptures, its own deities, its own rituals; that an individual is, by birth or by conversion, a member of one such community and not others; and that the principal way of identifying a person spiritually is to ask, *what religion are you?*

Almost none of this was true — as a way of framing human spiritual life — in the world in which the *Gītā* was composed.

#### The root √dhr̥ and the seven meanings of *dharma*

The Sanskrit word *dharma* (धर्म) derives from the verbal root √dhr̥, "to hold, to bear, to sustain, to uphold." At its etymological core, the word simply means:

*"that which holds things together,"*

*"that which sustains being,"*

*"the upholding-principle."*

From this single root the word radiates into a constellation of context-dependent meanings. Sanskrit thinkers were entirely comfortable with this multiplicity; classical Indian grammar treats it not as a defect but as a feature of the language's economy. A single word can do the work of many because the context will determine which sense is active.

| SENSE OF DHARMA            | WHAT IT POINTS TO                                                                                   | EXAMPLE IN USE                                                          |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Cosmic / natural law    | The order that holds the universe together — gravity, seasons, causality, the structure of reality. | "The dharma of fire is to burn; the dharma of water is to flow."        |
| 2. Moral / ethical law     | Right conduct; what one ought to do; the principles that make human life possible.                  | "Truthfulness is dharma. Non-violence is dharma. Compassion is dharma." |
| 3. Duty of role or station | The obligations specific to one's position in life — as parent, teacher, ruler, friend.             | "It is the king's dharma to protect; the teacher's dharma to instruct." |

| SENSE OF <i>DHARMA</i>       | WHAT IT POINTS TO                                                                                  | EXAMPLE IN USE                                                         |
|------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 4. <b>Vocation / calling</b> | The particular work that one's nature equips one to do; one's <i>sva-dharma</i> — own-dharma.      | <i>"A warrior's dharma differs from a poet's; both are necessary."</i> |
| 5. <b>Intrinsic nature</b>   | The essential character of a thing — what it is, irrespective of what one might wish it were.      | <i>"It is the dharma of a river to find the sea."</i>                  |
| 6. <b>Law / justice</b>      | The proper procedure; what is fair, what is binding, what holds society together.                  | <i>"The court was convened to determine dharma in the matter."</i>     |
| 7. <b>Spiritual practice</b> | The path that holds the soul in alignment with reality — meditation, virtue, the search for truth. | <i>"He took up the dharma of contemplation in his later years."</i>    |

None of these seven senses corresponds to "religion" as a sectarian identity. Notice, in particular, that all seven describe *what one does, is, or upholds* — none describes a *group one belongs to*. *Dharma* is action and nature; it is not membership.

To translate *dharma* as "religion" is therefore not merely imprecise — it is a category error. It is like translating the Sanskrit word for "river" with the English word "passport." Both words occupy meaningful places in their respective languages; neither is the other's equivalent.

## When did "religion" become a category?

The English word *religion* derives from the Latin *religio*, which in classical and early-medieval Latin did not mean what it means today. *Religio* in Cicero and Augustine meant something closer to "reverence," "scrupulous observance," or "what binds one in awe." It was a quality of a person's inner life, not the name of a system one belonged to. A Roman would not have said "I am of the Roman religion" any more than a person today would say "I am of the English ethics."

The modern meaning of "religion" — a discrete, named system of belief, distinguished from other such systems, to which one belongs as a member — is a remarkably late development. The historian of religion **Wilfred Cantwell Smith**, in his 1962 study *The Meaning and End of Religion*, argues persuasively that this usage emerges only in the 17th century in Europe, and that it then spreads outward as European nations encounter — and bureaucratically classify — the populations of their colonies.

*The very concept "your religion vs. their religion" is, in this sense, a concept of the early modern European period. It is not a concept that the ancient world — Indian, Greek, Egyptian, Chinese, Persian, Hebrew — could have employed, because the underlying framework simply did not yet exist.*

Consider what the ancient world had instead:

- In India, one followed a *dharma* — a way of life, a set of obligations, a discipline. One did not "belong to Hinduism," because Hinduism (as a named, bounded entity) did not exist as a category. The word *Hindu* itself is Persian in origin and was used by outsiders, geographically, to refer to anyone east of the Indus river. It became an "identity" only when foreign administrators needed a label.
- In Greece, one honored the gods, observed the festivals, and pursued virtue (*aretē*). Greeks did not say they "had a religion"; they said they were Athenian, Spartan, Theban.
- In ancient Israel, one walked in the way of the Lord — *halakhah*, "the walking." The category of "the Jewish religion" as one religion among several is, again, a much later imposition.
- In China, one cultivated the *Tao* (the Way) or the *li* (proper conduct). Confucians, Taoists, and Buddhists in China did not see themselves as members of competing religions; they often practiced elements of all three simultaneously.
- In the Buddha's time (~500 BCE), the teaching offered was *dhamma* (the Pāli form of *dharma*) — a path, a discipline, a way. The Buddha did not "found a religion." He taught a method.

When, in the 16th–19th centuries, European Christians arrived in India and asked, "*What is your religion?*" — there was no clean Sanskrit answer, because the question presupposed a category Indians had not yet been forced to fit themselves into. Eventually, under sustained colonial pressure, Indians began to use *dharma* as the translation for the foreign word *religion*. This was a pragmatic accommodation. It has been, philosophically, a disaster.

## The cost of the mistranslation

Two words were damaged when *dharma* was forced to mean "religion."

**The word "religion" was inflated.** It came to seem as if "religion" named the deepest possible category of human spiritual life — as if everyone, of every age, must have had one. (They didn't; the category is recent.) This inflation made it natural to suppose that "religions" had always competed with one another in the way they appear to now, and that the central question of any spiritual life was: *which religion is yours?* The Gītā, asked this question, has no answer — because the question is not yet possible inside the text's own framework.

**The word *dharma* was shrunk.** It came to seem as if *dharma* was just the Indian word for "religion" — as if "Hindu dharma" was simply "the Hindu religion." This shrinkage hollowed out a word that had carried, for thousands of years, the meanings of cosmic order, moral law, personal calling, intrinsic nature, and spiritual practice. A word that could once name the principle by which a river finds the sea was reduced to a label on a census form.

The cost of this double damage is most visible in how the Gītā's verse on *sva-dharma* and *para-dharma* (BG 3.35, repeated at 18.47) is now usually read.

### The mistranslated verse

| Source                                                  | The verse                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Sanskrit (BG 3.35)                                      | श्रेयान्स्वधर्मो विगुणः परधर्मात्स्वनुष्ठितात् ।<br>स्वधर्मे निधनं श्रेयः परधर्मो भयावहः ॥<br><i>śreyān sva-dharmo viguṇaḥ para-dharmāt sv-anuṣṭhitāt  </i><br><i>sva-dharme nidhanaṁ śreyaḥ para-dharmo bhayāvahaḥ   </i> |
| Common English rendering<br>(philologically inaccurate) | "Better one's own <b>religion</b> , however imperfect, than another's well performed.<br>Better to die in one's own <b>religion</b> than to thrive in another's, which is fraught with danger."                            |
| Accurate rendering<br>(faithful to original meaning)    | "Better one's <b>own calling</b> , however imperfectly performed, than another's well performed.<br>Better to die in one's <b>own work</b> than to thrive in <b>someone else's</b> , which is fraught with peril."         |

The Sanskrit words *sva* and *para* mean simply "own" and "other-than-self." They do not carry the tribal-collective sense that the English word "religion" automatically imports. *Sva-dharma* is the calling, vocation, role, and intrinsic nature that belongs to a particular person at a particular moment of their life. *Para-dharma* is someone *else's* calling — a life that is not yours, work that is not yours, a role that does not arise from your own nature.

What the verse actually warns against, then, is **inauthenticity** — the temptation to live another's life because it appears easier, more prestigious, or more profitable than one's own. It is a verse against imitation, against pretense, against the slow ruin of a self that is trying to be what it is not.

## What the verse actually says

Read with the word restored, BG 3.35 says something like this:

*It is better to do your own work, even badly, than to do someone else's work well.*

*It is better to die in your own calling than to flourish in someone else's.*

*The other path — however attractive — is fraught with peril, because it is not yours.*

The peril the verse names is not the peril of falling into the wrong tribe. It is the peril of **living someone else's life** — of building a career, a self, a reputation that does not arise from one's own nature, and that therefore will not, when tested, hold. The verse can be heard by an accountant who has always known she was meant to be a teacher; by a warrior who has been pretending to be a priest; by a poet who has been forcing himself to be a soldier because that is what his father was. In every case, the counsel is the same: *be honestly the one you are. Even your imperfect honesty is worth more than another's perfect imitation.*

This is a teaching about authenticity, not about tribal allegiance. It cannot be used to justify staying in a community one has outgrown, refusing to cross a boundary one is called to cross, or denying the legitimacy of another's spiritual path. It says nothing about any of these things. It says only: **be the one you actually are.**

## The cost of getting this wrong

The harm done by reading *dharma* as "religion" is not abstract. Whenever a society begins to read the great wisdom texts of any tradition as if they were instructions to defend an identity-label against other identity-labels, three things follow.

First, the texts are reduced. A teaching that originally addressed the deepest questions of human life — *who am I? what should I do? how shall I die?* — is recast as a tribal manifesto, suitable only for fortifying boundaries.

Second, the texts are weaponized. The same verses that, properly read, would call a person inward to honest self-examination, are instead recruited to call them outward against the named other. *Sva-dharma* stops meaning "be yourself" and starts meaning "be against them." The text has not changed; only the reading has changed. But the consequences are real.

Third, and most quietly, the readers themselves are damaged. To read a wisdom text as a tribal weapon is to be deprived of what the text was actually trying to give. A reader who arrives at the Gītā expecting "*my religion better than yours*" will leave with what they brought; they will not have heard what the Gītā actually said. And the Gītā, in the meantime, will continue to say it, quietly, to anyone whose translation does not get in the way.

## What is being recovered, not what is being attacked

Nothing in this reflection is an attack on any tradition, any reader, any community, or any translator who has rendered *dharma* as "religion" in good faith. Many of the great twentieth-century translators did precisely that, often because the available English vocabulary did not give them a better option. The remedy is not to blame the translators but to learn what they had no easy way to convey.

What is being recovered is a Sanskrit word with seven meanings and a 3,000-year history. What is being recovered is a verse that was never about tribes. What is being recovered, behind the verse, is a teaching that the Gītā shares with the wisdom literature of every culture that has thought carefully about how to live: **be the one you actually are. Do the work that is yours. Do not imitate. Do not defect to another's life because it looks easier. The road of your own becoming, even when it is hard, is the only one that leads anywhere worth arriving at.**

This teaching is not the property of India, or of Sanskrit, or of any sectarian community. It is the property of anyone who has ever stood at the door of an unlive life and wondered whether to enter. The Gītā has been saying so for two and a half thousand years. The translation has, intermittently, gotten in the way. The translation can be corrected.

The next reflection asks a related question: what does the Gītā itself say about people whose paths and practices differ from the speaker's? Does the text — read in its own Sanskrit, on its own terms — provide any support for sectarian self-righteousness at all? The answer, perhaps surprisingly, is contained entirely within the text's own verses. They will be the only sources cited.

— *the writer, with humility and gratitude.*

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